THE KEEFE TEAM · JLA REALTY · ALEDO, TEXAS

Buying Rental Property in Fort Worth & Parker County

Most agents can show you a house. Fewer have bought one at a discount, rebuilt it with their own crew, rented it, and watched the numbers for years. Jennifer has flipped more than 20 houses and personally owns and manages more than 15 rentals, long-term and short-term, along with running a construction company. This is how we look at an investment property, and what's different about investing in Fort Worth and Parker County.



Lisa Keefe, Broker Associate, SRES® · Jennifer Keefe, REALTOR® · 817-807-3367 · keefeteamrealty.com

1. Decide what kind of investor you are first

A long-term rental, a short-term rental, a flip and a house you'll hold for land value are four different businesses. They want different neighborhoods, different financing and different amounts of your time. A duplex near TCU and a 5-acre place outside Weatherford are both "investment property," and almost nothing about them is the same.

Tell us your goal: monthly cash flow, equity you can pull later, a place for family someday, or a project you can work on. We'll point you at the right part of the map.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Pick the strategy, then the property. Investors who do it the other way around end up with a house that doesn't fit any plan.**

2. Run the numbers the way a lender and a landlord would

Start with realistic rent, from actual comparable leases, not a website estimate. Subtract taxes (Texas property taxes are high and non-homestead property gets no exemption cap), insurance, maintenance, vacancy, management if you won't self-manage, and the mortgage. What's left is the number that matters. Then look at what you'd have to put in up front: down payment, closing costs, and the repairs it needs before it rents.

Jennifer will walk the property and give you a real repair number, not a guess. That's usually where investment deals are won or lost.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Underwrite with the real tax bill after the sale, not the seller's. In Texas, that reset can erase your cash flow.**

3. Where the rentals work west of Fort Worth

Fort Worth's west side and the towns along I-20 have steady rental demand from Lockheed, the hospital districts, the rail and logistics jobs, and families priced out of Aledo ISD who still want to be close. Weatherford has Weatherford College, a growing medical corridor and a county-seat economy. Aledo and Willow Park rent high but sell high too, so they're often better equity plays than cash-flow plays.

Short-term rentals do well near Lake Weatherford, the Parker County horse-show venues and the Fort Worth Stockyards and Cultural District, but check each city's short-term rental rules first; they're changing.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Cash flow lives in the $200K–$350K band west of Loop 820. Appreciation lives closer to Aledo. Know which one you're buying.**

4. What to look for on a walk-through

Roof, foundation, HVAC, water heater, electrical panel, plumbing type, and drainage around the house. Those are the items that eat a renovation budget. Cosmetic problems (paint, flooring, kitchens from 1995) are where the opportunity is, because most buyers can't see past them and we can price them to the dollar.

On older Fort Worth houses, ask about cast-iron drain lines, aluminum wiring and foundation repair history. On acreage rentals, the well and septic are your responsibility, not a tenant's.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Buy the ugly house with good bones. Never the pretty house with a bad foundation.**

5. Financing an investment property

Conventional investment loans typically want 15–25% down and carry a higher rate than a primary residence. DSCR loans qualify on the property's rent instead of your income, which helps once you own several. Hard money and private lenders fund flips fast at a higher cost. House-hacking (living in one unit of a duplex or in the house while you renovate) can get you owner-occupied terms on your first one.

Jennifer has used most of these. We can introduce you to lenders who close investment deals in Parker and Tarrant County on time.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Line up financing before you shop. Investment sellers take offers from buyers who can close, and the clock on a good deal is short.**

6. Buying off-market and buying distressed

Some of the best deals never hit the MLS: estates, tired landlords, pre-foreclosures and houses that need too much work for a retail buyer. We see those because of the circles we run in, and we'll tell you honestly when a "deal" isn't one. If you're buying something distressed, budget for the unknowns, get a real inspection even if you're buying as-is, and make sure the title is clean before you spend a dollar on it.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Price the worst case, then decide. If it only works when everything goes right, it doesn't work.**

7. The renovation, done right and done fast

Every month a property sits is a mortgage payment with no rent. Scope the work before closing, line up the trades, and have materials on order the day you get the keys. Permits matter in Fort Worth and the incorporated towns; unpermitted work shows up at resale. Rental finishes should be durable, not fancy: LVP floors, solid-surface counters, neutral paint, good lighting.

Jennifer's crews do this for a living. Whether you use them or your own, you'll get a scope and a number you can trust.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Finish to the rent, not to your taste. Tenants pay for clean, bright and working.**

8. Managing it, or paying someone to

Self-managing one or two rentals is doable if you're organized: a good lease (Texas has specific rules on deposits, repairs and notices), tenant screening, a maintenance list and a bookkeeping system. Past three or four, most people are better off with a manager or a very good system. Jennifer manages her own portfolio, so ask her what actually works and what she'd skip.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Screen hard, maintain fast, document everything. Most landlord problems trace back to one of those three.**

9. Selling, 1031 exchanges and the long game

When it's time to sell, we market investment property to investors as well as retail buyers, with the rent roll and the numbers ready. If you're rolling into a bigger property, a 1031 exchange can defer the capital gains tax, but the deadlines are strict and the intermediary has to be in place before you close. Talk to your CPA early, and tell us so we can time both sides.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Every property should have an exit plan the day you buy it.**

Why work with us on this

You're getting an agent who has done the thing you're trying to do, in the market you're trying to do it in, with her own money. We'll tell you when to walk away. And when you buy, the trailer is yours for the move-in or the turnover.

Questions we hear most

Is Parker County a good place for rental property?

It depends on the strategy. Aledo and Willow Park are strong for appreciation and attract quality tenants but cash flow is thin at today's prices. Weatherford, Springtown and west Fort Worth offer better rent-to-price ratios. We'll show you both with real numbers.

Do I need an LLC?

Many investors hold rentals in an LLC for liability reasons, but it affects financing and insurance. Talk to a Texas attorney and your CPA; we'll coordinate with them on how title is taken.

Can Jennifer's company do the renovation?

Often, yes. Home Glow Exteriors handles roofing and exteriors, and Jennifer has crews for interior work. You're never obligated to use them; you'll get an honest scope either way.

What about short-term rentals?

They can out-earn long-term rentals in the right spot but take more work and face changing city rules. Fort Worth, Weatherford and the smaller towns each handle them differently. We'll check the current rules for any property you're considering.

Thinking about your first rental, or your next one? Tell us the strategy and we'll find the property.

The Keefe Team · 817-807-3367 · lisa@lisakeefe.realtor · keefeteamrealty.com

Lisa Keefe, Broker Associate (TX #0691469) · Jennifer Keefe, REALTOR® (TX #0781916) · JLA Realty · Texas law requires license holders to provide the Information About Brokerage Services and Consumer Protection Notice: keefeteamrealty.com/iabs-consumer-protection-notice.pdf · This guide is general information, not legal, tax or financial advice.